

This project, which was partly funded by Boeing and National Science Foundation, can also be useful for physically-challenged people to work with robots.

Calling robots electronic persons, is it a slip or the scary truth

Astro Teller, head of X (formerly Google X), the advanced technology lab of Alphabet, explained in a recent IEEE interview that washing machines, dishwashers, drones, smart cars and the like are robots though these might not be jazzy-looking bipeds. These are intelligent, help us do something and save us time. If you look at it that way, smart robots are really all around us.

It is easy to even build your own robot and make it smart, with simple components and open source tools. Maybe not something that looks like Rosie or Baxter, but you can surely create a quick and easy AI agent. OpenAI Universe, for example, lets you train an AI agent to use a computer like a human does. With Universe, the agent can look at screen pixels and operate a virtual keyboard and mouse. The agent can be trained to do any task that you can achieve using a computer.

Sadly, the garbage-in-garbage-out principle is true for robotics and AI, too. Train it to do something good and it will. Train it to do something bad and it will. No questions asked. Anticipating such misuse, the industry is getting together to regulate the space and implement best practices. One example is Partnership on Artificial Intelligence to Benefit People and Society, comprising companies like Google's DeepMind division, Amazon, Facebook, IBM and Microsoft. The website speaks of best practices, open engagement and ethics, trustworthiness, reliability, robustness and other relevant issues.

The European Parliament, too, put forward a draft report urging the

creation and adoption of EU-wide rules to manage the issues arising from the widespread use of robots and AI. The draft helps us understand the need to standardise and regulate the constantly mushrooming variety of robots, ranging from industrial robots, care robots, medical robots, entertainment robots and drones to farming robots.

The report explores the issues of liability, accountability and safety, and raises issues that make us pinch ourselves and understand that yes, we are really co-existing with robots. For example, who will pay when a robot or a self-driving car meets with an accident, when robots will need to be designated as electronic persons, how to ensure they are good ones and so on. The report asserts the need to create a European agency for robotics and AI to support the regulation and legislation efforts, the need to define and classify robots and smart robots, create a robot registration system, improve interoperability and so on.

However, it is the portion about robots being called electronic persons that has raised a lot of eyebrows and caused a lot of buzz among experts. Once personhood is associated with something, issues like ownership, insurance and rights come into play, making the relationship much more complex.

Comfortingly, one of the experts had commented that since we build robots, these are like machine slaves, and we can choose not to build robots that would mind being owned. In the words of Joanna Bryson, a working member of IEEE Ethically Aligned Design project, "We are not obliged to build robots that we end up feeling obliged to."

When equipped with self-learning capabilities, what if they learn to rebel? Remember how K-2SO swapped sides in Star Wars movie Rogue One? Is there such a thing as trusted autonomy? Well, another day, another discussion! **EFY**



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